MEDIATOR GUIDE TO PERSONAL GROWTH

Deepen your self-awareness, find your purpose, and make the world a better place

16Personalities

Table of Contents

Introduction 3
Facets of Personal Growth 5
Self-Esteem 6
Balanced Self-Esteem 6
Unbalanced Self-Esteem 8
Rebalancing Self-Esteem 9
Self-Respect 12
Balanced Self-Respect 12
Unbalanced Self-Respect 13
Rebalancing Self-Respect 14
Self-Confidence 16
Balanced Self-Confidence 16
Unbalanced Self-Confidence 17
Rebalancing Self-Confidence 18
Self-Evolution 20
Balanced Self-Evolution. 20
Unbalanced Self-Evolution 21
Rebalancing Self-Evolution 22
Self-Responsibility 25
Balanced Self-Responsibility 25
Unbalanced Self-Responsibility 25
Rebalancing Self-Responsibility 26
Final Words 29
So... What's Next? 30

Introduction

Why Personal Growth Matters to Mediators

For people with the Mediator personality type, personal growth isn't a trivial matter. Instead, it's an eye-opening, invigorating, and potentially life-changing process that takes Mediators on a journey toward one of their most cherished ideals: deepening their understanding of themselves.

While Mediators may appear calm on the outside, on the inside they brim with passion, imagination, and curiosity. If you're a Mediator, people might describe you as "enigmatic" or "mysterious" – and in truth, Mediators can be a bit mysterious even to themselves. These types run deep – so deep that they may need to dedicate real time and energy to reflecting on their own motivations, desires, and sense of purpose. Without this space for contemplation and awareness, Mediators may feel muddled in their daily life, struggling to make progress in the direction of their ideals.

This is a problem, because Mediators' ideals – including peace, understanding, harmony, and empathy – are incredibly important to them. Sensitive to the core, people with this personality type can become quite discouraged with themselves when they don't figure out how to turn their dreams into reality. In these moments, Mediators may grapple with questions such as, "Who am I?," "What is my purpose?," and "How can I make this world a better place?" The key is to reflect on these questions in a way that prompts change and growth, rather than simply more questions.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

A Way Forward

In this guide, Mediators will learn how to cultivate an inward understanding and appreciation of themselves. But the work of personal growth is external as well as internal, so Mediators will also learn how to translate their thoughts, ideas, and beliefs into outward action in their daily lives. This two-pronged approach enables Mediators to feel connected with the world at large – and their place within it.

In a way, personal growth means becoming a hero and fulfilling a hero's quest in one's own life. Everyone has an image of what their life should be, and growth is about finding a path to fulfillment while overcoming obstacles that get in the way. Some of the recommendations in these pages may require Mediators to venture beyond their comfort zone and the things that they've tried so far in their quest for fulfillment. But the reward is well worth the effort. By learning to balance their rich imagination and emotional depth with external action and direction, Mediators can gain the clarity and energy that they need to grow and expand in the ways that matter most to them.

Facets of Personal Growth

As part of a comprehensive view of personal growth for Mediators, we've separated the necessary components down into distinct facets. The first three facets of personal growth are motivational, and fulfilling them helps Mediators identify a more satisfying life. The latter two are more tactical and require a more proactive approach. When questioning the role that personal growth plays in a Mediator's life, the first three facets are more likely to answer "Why?," while the final two focus more on "How?"

The following reflective qualities hinge on self-awareness, an essential source of motivation for Mediators. In order to be happy, productive, and fulfilled, they must nurture these facets.

- **Self-esteem** speaks to how much Mediators like themselves.
- **Self-respect** speaks to Mediators' sense of their worth.
- **Self-confidence** is where Mediators find the energy that moves them forward in life.

The following developmental strategies speak to the more active aspects of personal growth. Attending to the first three facets of personal growth often facilitates further development through these facets.

- **Self-evolution** describes a path of development that Mediators must follow to more fully reach their potential.
- **Self-responsibility** is Mediators' ability to take charge of their decisions and accept the consequences for doing so.

Much of Mediators' rationale for their thoughts, attitudes, and actions comes from trying to satisfy these needs and successfully meet their potential. An imbalance in any of the five facets, and particularly the first three, can become a source of overwhelming difficulty.

Mediators gain energy and personal power from discovering deep truths about themselves. Those who feel that they fall short on self-esteem, self-respect, or self-confidence may turn to endless rumination in search of self-discovery, forgetting that many of those truths arise from engaging with other people and living in the material world. Personal reflection is a strength, but when Mediators immerse themselves too much in introspection, problems occur.

In the following sections, we'll first explore balanced Mediators, who successfully use their strengths and adjust for their weaknesses while satisfying the three reflective qualities and employing self-evolution and self-responsibility. Then we'll consider some possible challenges that Mediators can face should they decide that they aren't meeting their potential or engaging properly with their core personalities – in other words, if they become unbalanced.

Imbalance often occurs when individuals lose their sense of self-esteem, self-respect, or self-confidence, and it can lead Mediators to either inflate the importance of a characteristic or underutilize a strength. It can also involve not fully understanding the course that they need to take to lead a more satisfying life. Such situations can be the product of conscious choices that they make or subconscious impulses – so, finally, we'll suggest activities to start Mediators on the path to restoring balance.

Self-Esteem

Mediators get their self-esteem – how much they like themselves – from their belief in their beliefs. They revere their beliefs and find a purpose in holding onto them. To them, their inner world is real, and nurturing it is important.

Balanced Self-Esteem

The Quality of Inspiration

On the surface, Mediators appear mild and temperate, and in many ways, they are – which leads many people to underestimate the passion of Mediators. Within these gentle souls, their dedication to justice, peace, and equality churn like a storm. The self-appreciation of these types comes from a powerful sense of connection to these thoughts, and they often wonder why the rest of the world doesn't feel the same. Mediators believe that the planet would be a better place if others were more introspective. To people with this personality type, deep insights gained through self-exploration are a precious commodity – the more they feel that they possess these deep insights, the more worth they see in themselves.

Mediators serve meaning on a platter, first to themselves and then, less so, to others – not as a matter of selfishness but as a product of their sensitivity. This tendency leaves them guarded and private. Given the cultural bias in favor of the Extraverted, some may believe that this means that Mediators offer little to the world, yet their insular, dreamy natures foster independent thought and being. When they share their perspectives, they often strike others as quite unique and creative – it's no accident that these types find their worth in their rich inner musings.

Mediators may boost their own self-esteem by contributing to a cause or even joining a movement, but they're less social warriors than philosophers and visionaries with lessons to share, preferably in emotionally safe and inviting settings. They often work in helping or teaching professions where they can more readily use their empathy and share their insights to small groups or individuals. They're likely to listen intently and internalize what others say. Sometimes, these types fulfill their purpose best with silence. Listening and understanding are enough to give them meaning. They're the people in the workplace who lend support to others, which may be more emotional than practical. Nonetheless, they provide an attentive ear or a shoulder to cry on. Mediators regard positive human connection as a self-affirmation, so they seek out ways to be attentive and encouraging in their quiet way.

Belief without Dogma

Beyond their insight and idealism, Mediators have open minds and nonjudgmental attitudes when they have everything in perspective. Their ideals and beliefs are essential to their self-esteem, and they would never rob others of their beliefs and ideals, however drastically they may differ from their own.

In true Mediator form, they often support the rights of others to live and believe as they wish just as passionately as they would defend their own choices. If they follow an activist's lifestyle, they may become involved in organizations that support the rights of others to live as they choose. Because most prefer individual connections outside organized causes, their tolerance is most obvious in their daily lives. For them, affording others the same freedom of thought and behavior that they enjoy themselves is an encouraging act. Doing so allows Mediators to feel as though they have contributed to an individual's or a culture's quality of life.

Unbalanced Self-Esteem

Things go off-kilter with self-esteem when Mediators are too protective of that which gives them a positive self-view or when they feel that they must prove to themselves (and perhaps to others) that they're open-minded and supportive people. Either way, they may act in maladaptive ways to guard their self-esteem against assault.

When Connections Hurt

Mediators often hide their sensitivity. Those who aren't close to them may never see how easily people of this type can be hurt. They may even trick themselves into believing they aren't as sensitive as they are. Mediators who haven't acknowledged and understood their sensitivities may experience a veiled undercurrent of reactivity that affects everything in their lives.

People with this personality type are protective of the qualities that make them unique. Because their worth is bundled with their ideas and ponderings, when those ideas are dismissed or attacked, they take it personally and tend to nestle deeper into the safety of their inner lives. Consequently, Mediators are slow to share any of their inspired thoughts and slow to let all but the most trusted people into their lives.

Mediators who haven't yet gained perspective on their sensitivity often detest conflict and criticism. No matter how objective or impersonal, criticism may strike these types as a misreading of their good intentions. Mediators who are already questioning themselves may be especially fragile in such instances – because of their sensitivity, they may interpret the flaws that others observe as an undermining of their whole purpose. For example, if a Mediator handed in a report with one section missing crucial data, they might feel like the error renders the entire report flawed and worthless. Mediators should avoid overgeneralizing when it comes to criticism.

Tolerance Becoming a Lack of Conviction

Mediators who keep a balanced perspective temper their open-mindedness and tolerance with an appreciation for the "big picture." They aren't likely to tolerate, for example, an extreme hate group – realizing the pervasive damage such a group could potentially inflict on

society, Mediators are likely to reject them or criticize them. However, when they lack the big picture, or when they cannot adequately respond for whatever reason, they may overcompensate, relying on a strength – in this case, tolerance – until it becomes a weakness. When an incident or event exceeds what they can tolerate, instead of passionate outrage, their reaction may be no more than an utterance: "Oh, my." They may find themselves allowing for behaviors that, from a more objective and balanced place, would feel inappropriate to them.

Mediators trying to restore a flagging sense of self-esteem may become so tolerant that they lose critical judgment in favor of an "everything goes" attitude. They so desperately want acceptance that they no longer allow negative possibilities to inform their opinions, or they miss critical specifics that could alter their reactions or opinions. Mediators typically don't allow harm, so they're likely to find their own stances confusing or contradictory at times. But they won't find much help for their self-esteem in holding ill-chosen positions. Others may confuse such exaggerated Mediator acceptance with apathy about people doing harm to themselves or others.

Rebalancing Self-Esteem

All Mediators can benefit from tempering their emotions and instincts with a dose of rationality. As these types mature, they learn to manage their emotional instincts and judge criticism more objectively. This gives them greater emotional stability. Nevertheless, it isn't an easy approach, as they largely allow their feelings to inform their decisions and actions.

Objectivity can help Mediators when they fear that criticism is eroding the positive self-view granted by their insights and opinions. They often need a perspective that allows them to see that criticism is often limited in its meaning and scope. Healthy Mediators recognize that criticism may not be personal, and even if it is personal, it may not be meaningful – critics sometimes harbor agendas that are at best unhelpful and at worst detrimental to the growth and progress of others. Learning to objectively assess criticism while recognizing the influence that their sensitivity can have on their reactions can help Mediators handle

critical comments more effectively. Once they banish the assumption that criticism inherently denounces their very being, they can then deal with feedback in a more constructive, less defensive manner.

Being too sensitive to criticism or conflict is often the product of Mediators indulging in assumptions. This is likely to occur if they elevate transitory emotions above their stable, long-term convictions or the reality of their environment. These types aren't alone in assuming more than they can prove, but it can create unique problems for them. One way for them to avoid toppling the tower of self-esteem is to fortify the foundation. One way to fortify self-esteem is with a game of "Test the Assumption":

- Write down a few assumptions you have: about your life, your work, your friends, your family.
- Every day that you want to play the game, choose one assumption as the "Assumption of the Day." For that day, you are focused on this assumption.
- Look for a way to test the assumption. In many cases, the best way is simply asking the right people the right questions.
    - For example, if the assumption is that a report is without any merit simply because a manager criticized one of the graphs, ask the manager to clarify what the criticism meant.
- Was your assumption correct? Great! You understand the world a little better than you might have thought.
- Was your assumption wrong? Great! You know with certainty that you had wrongly assumed, and now you can change that assumption.

Make it a point to spot assumptions throughout the day and test them as soon as possible. Even if they're hard to find, accept the challenge to look for them. Keep it on a game level and have a little fun.

Open-Minded, Yet Discerning

Mediators know well that not everything in life is good or worth supporting. Nonetheless, should they decide that they need to prove their value by showing how strong their empathy is, they may fail to

judge when judging is desirable. This can eventually backfire because they define their worth by compassionate connection to others, and an "anything goes" attitude counters that impulse in the long run. There is a difference between using judgment and being judgmental.

Shoring up their values and their sense of mission, no matter how often they change, is the best way to keep Mediators on track and judging wisely. The following exercise is one way to organize internal thoughts and ideas so that they can inform Mediators' outer actions and opinions in a consistent manner:

- Write three statements which quintessentially describe deeply-held values. You can write physical notes on Post-its or notecards, or use a digital note-keeping method.
- Post these value notes somewhere that you'll see them a lot: around the house, at the office, in your car. If you're keeping track digitally, add these notes to your phone, desktop background, or any other place where you can't miss them.
- Throughout the day, consider these three values and how you apply them, if at all.
    - If they aren't being applied, consider ways to act on them. Consider discussing the subject with a close friend.
- After one week of posting up your values, consider all three statements. It isn't unusual to discover that some values come from external sources and aren't values that you genuinely embrace. Acknowledging this, and adjusting accordingly, is simply another form of growth. Revise any inconsistent values and continue as desired.

Mediators' positive self-esteem comes from the sense that they understand others in a significant and constructive way. Built into this are tolerance and a need to support the growth and well-being of others without judging or forcing them to walk a specific path. When Mediators' self-esteem serves them well, those qualities shine in their pure form without any defensive or hidden motives.

Self-Respect

People who have positive self-respect are people who see their own worth. When self-respect is strong, they have no fear of looking in their mental mirrors because what they see reflects their values. People who respect themselves are obviously happier and more satisfied with their lives. Beyond that, they're likely to care for themselves better and make better choices. People do more for those they believe are worthy and, therefore, treat them better. The same principle applies to seeing oneself as worthy.

Balanced Self-Respect

Mediators respect themselves most when they believe that they help victims of evil and injustice, especially when they simultaneously discover more about themselves. They want to see themselves as a humane force in the world, but not necessarily through big acts – just big ideas. Doing good may be personal or global, and their altruistic efforts can be as simple as boosting a single child's self-esteem or as ambitious as working to solve world hunger. These heroes are likely to be more inspirational than hands on, and they benefit from others organizing the rescue while they gently provide the emotional and motivational support.

To the (Emotional) Rescue

Concern for others consumes Mediators, and they dream of ways that they can help make the world a better place. They value integrity above all else. Some may support political movements with positive agendas, yet many prefer to find individual ways to make a difference and support others. Making sure that those around them feel comfortable, providing them a shoulder to cry on, listening attentively to their concerns – these are just some of the ways that Mediators show respect to others. They feel that they're at their best when they help people they care about gain insight and a richer understanding of themselves. As a bonus, they end up liking themselves as well.

Embracing Something Bigger

The blocks that build Mediators' self-respect are more than simple good deeds. They live in a world of ideas and theories, and their

notions always have a central human element. Their emotions sway their understanding, as if they possess a kind of ethical DNA that influences their attitudes and outcomes. Although their code may evolve, Mediators do good for others based on more high-minded purposes than simple, practical needs.

People with this personality type remind the world to think beyond petty and self-centered concerns. They may not be on street corners shouting about the ways humankind should live, but quietly, and in everyday ways, Mediators live with an eye toward moral standards. This doesn't mean that their actions always align with their ideals – nobody is perfect. However, when they take the moral high ground – mostly in their thoughts and occasionally in the things that they do – Mediators can look at themselves with respect.

Unbalanced Self-Respect

Unfulfilled Idealism

Mediators' extreme idealism, paired with their occasional journeys deep into their own imaginations, can lead to impossible expectations. They often care so much about an idea that they struggle to accept the reality that its execution may not be perfect. A winnowing process is required to separate a good idea or two from the many others that can end up creating an overwhelming flood of unfulfilled intentions. If Mediators need to realize their ideals fully before they can like themselves, they'll always suffer from poor self-respect.

Should they attempt to bring about the ideal by doing good works, perfectionistic Mediators are likely to notice only the aspects that are "not quite perfect." It becomes obvious that they can't do good to the degree that their idealism demands, potentially resulting in frustration and surrender to a deep sense of failure and ineffectiveness.

Talking Down to Themselves

Some Mediators have trouble creating or preserving positive self-respect because their intentions often go unrealized. They sincerely want to help improve the lives of others, and they have strong convictions about how that should happen. But they don't always have the focus needed

to pull together a working plan. If their inability to turn a constellation of emotions into effective actions becomes too troubling, their self-talk may home in on their own perceived hypocrisies and failures.

In such instances, Mediators may take a more dogmatic approach to the causes they value, trying to convince themselves and others of their fervent belief in helping people. Such uncharacteristically passionate displays can overshadow the observable fact that they aren't acting on their convictions. If their goals and intentions are stated loudly and persistently enough, everyone might forget the sparseness of the results – or so many Mediators may believe, for a time.

Rebalancing Self-Respect

Setting Realistic Goals

Idealism can be noble, but when taken too far, it masks reality. Mediators are among the most idealistic personality types, apt to rely on their hearts instead of their heads when making decisions. Their imaginations are so fertile and filled with principles that organizing them into action – and even finding a place to begin – can be a challenge.

Being rational isn't the same as being heartless, however, and injecting pragmatism into a plan doesn't have to water down compassion. Mediators may see rationality and compassion as incompatible entities. This is a false dichotomy – in fact, being sensible is necessary to making a difference in the world. Filtering principles, beliefs, and visions through rationality while still honoring their emotional decision-making preference allows these types to create goals that lead to more intentional results.

Mediators may need to work toward goals to know whether they're being effective. Good planning takes concepts beyond dreams and visions and turns them into action. Some research has found a correlation between individuals with anxiety and depression and people whose goals are vague. While this is by no means the case for all Mediators, it suggests that, with crisp and concrete goals, these types may feel better about themselves.

Here are some steps to facilitate specific goal-setting:

- Decide on a goal, and create a short list of statements. Avoid words such as "feeling" and "being." Use measurable action words, such as "provide," "build," "promote," "expand," "develop," "deliver," and "streamline." Make these statements so precise that the physical movement fills the mind's eye.
- Use numbers to define success. For example, "Expand the food bank's program to distribute 300 lunches to the homeless around town every Saturday."
- Consider whether the goal, as established, is achievable. This entails knowing deeper information about the absolute statements and numbers you've already set.
    - In the above example, this means asking, "Can we gather the ingredients, assemble the lunches, and find 300 people to feed on a Saturday afternoon? Will we have enough food, enough workers, and enough clients to make this a viable venture?" Approached in this manner, the achievement of the goal is quantifiable.

Overcoming Negativity

When they're overwhelmed by their idealistic and perfectionistic tendencies, Mediators may find themselves resorting to negativity, becoming judgmental, and even isolating themselves – a dangerous habit for this sensitive personality type. As their self-respect partly comes from helping others find their potential, vision, and happiness, they're unlikely to satisfy it if they isolate themselves either physically or emotionally.

Once these types realize that they can accept or even celebrate their imperfections, they're likely to ease up on themselves, and they can begin to appreciate things about themselves that they'd never noticed or had even seen as flaws. A sense of humor can help a lot with this.

Here are some steps to begin a journey to a more positive sense of worth – normal human blemishes and all:

- Choose an activity that is challenging but not overwhelming, such as participating in a sport or artistic activity or doing a small home repair. (Pay attention to all safety issues, and keep in mind that a good challenge is difficult but not impossible.)
- Engage in the activity knowing that good enough is sometimes good enough.
- When finished, assess the activity. Was it perfect? Even if it wasn't, was it a worthy effort? Celebrate the flaws with a good laugh.
- Ponder what the exercise says about being perfect.

When Mediators have a negative perspective, it's often the result of unrealistic expectations and an inability to fulfill their imagined ideals. For these types, embracing optimism can seem overwhelming, especially during difficult times, and yet the easiest way is to counter perfectionism with forgiveness – the same forgiveness Mediators give so easily to others.

Self-Confidence

Self-confidence reflects the energy channeled when individuals trust in their thoughts, feelings, and abilities. The greater the self-confidence, the more energy goes into moving forward in life. Although many elements influence how confidently people live, members of each personality type have distinctive traits that affect their self-confidence levels.

Balanced Self-Confidence

Who They Hope to Be

Mediators get their confidence from feeling connected to their own identity and aspirations. Anything these types regard as phony disappoints them – Mediators try to be as "real" as possible, and masks, lies, and insincerity cause them great uneasiness and disappointment. However, living according to their ideals can be a tall order. Their rich imagination always entertains thoughts of how the world, and all its inhabitants, should operate.

Going through life with such aims can provide Mediators with an optimistic outlook that they can use to encourage themselves and others to be better people. When Mediators lend an ear to others, as they often do, they advise with a sense of self-assurance because their advice is heartfelt and feels honest. Grounded Mediators find confidence not so much in what they do but in what they dream. Whenever they can connect even a part of such dreams to the world around them, it bolsters their confidence and helps them move forward with a sense of purpose.

Maintaining Confidence in a Material World

Although they're focused inward, Mediators still live in the physical world and must find enough confidence to persevere in that realm. When motivated, they adopt positive characteristics that bring sufficient measures of outward success or, at the very least, survival. (After all, even these gentle dreamers cannot dream up their next meal, so they must attend to the practical business of living.) Even when adapting to the outer world, Mediators never wander far from their imaginative inner lives.

Those seeking guidance are unlikely to be satisfied with following conventional advice for achieving happiness and success, some of which they may see as superficial or incomplete. Mediators often seek deeper wisdom through psychology, philosophy, religion, or "New Age" texts – disciplines that speak to their hearts as well as their minds and ground them in their unique way.

Unbalanced Self-Confidence

Honestly Inflexible

Mediators in a crisis of confidence may overcompensate by pushing their own agendas. Insecure people are often the loudest voices in the room. Mediators are usually very subdued, gentle people and rarely the loudest voice, but if intent on restoring their confidence, they can abandon their characteristic open-mindedness to serve themselves. Although rigidity and dogmatic behavior is clearly atypical for them, these are natural reactions for Mediators who doubt their connection to their core selves and feel compelled to reinforce it.

This tendency will backfire as Mediators impede the growth and well-being of others – and their own – with their new behaviors. To realign themselves with their principles, they may, paradoxically, lose sight of one of their overarching values: protecting the welfare of others. Being true to themselves doesn't necessarily entail centering their own preferences, but Mediators who doubt themselves and try to artificially inflate their confidence risk making this very mistake.

Deep Introspection

Those who are unsure of themselves may look even further inward than usual in search of further clues to their own identities and ways to fit that identity into their lives. This misses a crucial fact: people sometimes learn more about themselves by their responses to other people and by other people's response to them. Although letting others define them certainly isn't the standard path to personal growth for Mediators, navel-gazing isolation brought about by insecurity may rob them of an opportunity for more comprehensive self-discovery. These types can learn a lot about themselves from other people if they take the chance.

Mediators who cloister themselves to protect their true nature might well preserve a sense of integrity. A trip outside the metaphorical walls of their own isolation may allow other people to challenge, criticize, and perhaps even painfully reject them for simply being who they are. For Introverted types, isolation can be tempting. However, too much time worrying about what is "real" and "genuine" about themselves may, against their intentions, siphon away energy from expressing their realness and genuineness. Instead of securing their self-confidence as intended, too much inward focus can erode it. For real confidence, Mediators may need to break free of introspection long enough to practice what they ponder.

Rebalancing Self-Confidence

Restoring Open-Minded Confidence

True confidence allows people to act with the right measure of assuredness. Too little confidence means no energy. But Mediators artificially inflating confidence by stubbornly insisting that their reality

is superior to any other isn't a good option either. In the end, many Mediators find that lacking energy is easier to contend with than repelling the people they want to help. Better yet, these types should reconnect with that which gives them genuine confidence.

One way to rebalance self-confidence involves consciously connecting purpose and principles with the actions that Mediators take:

- List your ideals, purposes, and intentions. This list doesn't have to be complete or comprehensive, and it should be realistic and actionable.
- Support other people throughout your day in ways that are consistent with the values on the list. It can be as simple as encouraging a grocery clerk for carefully bagging groceries.
- Keep a tally of the people you've supported. Accountability, even to yourself, promotes a greater level of action.

Mediators develop and preserve self-confidence by approaching life with integrity and genuineness, such that their lives reflect their values and purpose. The above exercise can help them review what's important to them while encouraging outreach to others in small and large ways. Activities like this one promote connection between subjective values and objective actions – essential for restoring balance.

Testing Their Truths

To fulfill their identity needs, Mediators must cultivate their inner qualities in Introverted solitude and express them in the outer world. There is no "either/or" – both are necessary components for nurturing growth. Should these types find themselves concealing their genuine selves from the world, they may want to pursue tests of their identity in safe yet challenging ways. When solitude becomes isolation, Mediators should make a conscious effort to counteract unhelpful seclusion. An easy technique for nurturing connectedness is to share a meal.

- Choose a day within the next month to invite someone to lunch or dinner, someone who isn't a regular guest – an old friend or acquaintance, or a trustworthy person you've recently met.

- Don't cook? Eat out or order takeout. It's about the time together, not the food.
- Make sure to allow plenty of time so that this casual meeting isn't rushed. Relax and enjoy yourself.
- Whether it was a satisfying event or not, it was the opposite of isolation. If it wasn't satisfying, try another person. If it was, consider a follow-up meeting.

Self-Evolution

Self-evolution is the process of taking a more purposeful role in growth, understanding oneself better, and learning how to effect change in the world. For Mediators, this must include finding ways to act. Although they're often viewed as merely well-intentioned, people with this personality type can be so much more, and they're well-equipped with the imagination needed to breathe life into their dreams and visions.

Balanced Self-Evolution

Meeting Real Challenges

Mediators are very interested in growth, but self-evolution goes beyond the organic style of development many of them imagine. Self-evolution is a more deliberate scheme that allows people with this personality type to transform their lives for the better. Self-esteem, self-respect, and self-confidence fuel the self-evolution engine. Self-evolution returns the favor by organizing Mediators' responses to these three. When these are all working together, they create a powerful engine that propels their life toward fulfillment.

Mediators can take many paths to evolve. They might take a route created by someone else – maybe following spiritual, philosophical, or religious direction. Or, they might develop their own growth practices from various other sources and life experiences. Whatever their process for growth, it likely involves empathy, altruism, imaginative perspectives, and open-mindedness. Mediators distinguish between self-help as a utilitarian approach that brings them physical or emotional gains and self-growth as the natural result of living "correctly." Generally, if

they happen to pursue such practices, they're likely more aligned with meditation, which raises awareness, than with self-hypnosis, which pursues goals.

However, genuine growth for Mediators means that they have evolved to harness their dreams and extend them into the real world, translating vision into practice. Evolved Mediators have met the challenge this task represents, and in so doing they've unlocked their incredible potential.

Growth without End

Those who successfully advance in their self-evolution are aware of their strengths and weaknesses, and they develop life goals around them. However, that's only part of the story. As with all types, finding and utilizing their strengths alone isn't sufficient – becoming well-rounded and expanding beyond one's comfort zone are part of the formula for growth. For Mediators, this means attaching meaningful actions to their otherwise contemplative lives.

The famous saying, "Life is a journey, not a destination," rings true for most Mediators. Self-evolution is a continuing, lifelong course of digging deep into their beliefs and worldviews. More than most, Mediators see themselves in a state of perpetual transformation. Between their constantly shifting focus and their expansive imaginations, everything remains fluid. For them, no milestone along the way marks the completion of their developmental work because, in their view, they never finish. That may sound exhausting to some, but not knowing what "finished" looks like often excites Mediators.

Unbalanced Self-Evolution

Inflated Expectations

One of the difficulties that Mediators find with self-evolution is that their ideals are so utopian that it would be impossible to match them in real life. Excessively high expectations can become discouraging when trying to make those expectations happen. To make things more difficult, Mediators' thoughts resemble a web rather than a straight line – one notion veers off to three others, which veer off to nine more. It can be intimidating to untangle all of those thoughts into something

resembling a goal. It can be daunting to even find a starting place, much less a successful conclusion.

The unbalanced response to Mediators' gloriously tangled webs and lofty ideals is to treat them as ends in themselves. Trying to sort disparate strands into action plans often leads to frustration and can eventually result in a loss of confidence. Eventually, those who haven't found a way to pull all their thoughts into some reasonable, organized formation may become discouraged. One of their developmental challenges involves acting despite their own disorganization and staying hopeful about progress. For Mediators struggling with this imbalance, negative self-talk is likely to become the prominent voice in their heads.

A Mesmerizing Path

People with the Mediator personality type are not only fascinated by the ideas that their imagination creates – they experience awe at the wonders of the world around them. However, indulging their inner poets can entangle Mediators, who may even confuse their focus on beauty and wonder with genuine growth. The steps needed for practical development are unlikely to be found in an unending appreciation for abstract ideas and perpetual awe over the beauty of existence. On a practical level, a dream will never beat a plan.

As Lewis Carroll wrote, "If you don't know where you are going, any road will get you there." Mesmerized by the intangible and lacking any measurable goals, Mediators may find themselves on a road to nowhere. Life may start to feel empty for them as they, like everyone else, must exist in a material world where the common measure of success is the practical impact of an individual's life. Life may be a journey, but if that journey involves only meandering, then serious questions about purpose are likely to arise in the minds of the wanderers.

Rebalancing Self-Evolution

Embracing Growth Responsibly

When it comes to self-evolution, Mediators need to mind their tendency toward unrealistic expectations. Even more than this, they may want to address the things that they tell themselves that suggest that they can't

find a moderate and more practical path to growth. If they *believe* that they can sort out their web of beliefs and intentions and find a path that works, they're more likely to do just that. Fortunately, Mediators' imaginations, when martialed and organized, are just the tools they need to nurture positive beliefs that lead to strategies that work well for them.

For Mediators, true growth comes from granting themselves the same compassion and empathy that they give to others. This can include developing self-talk that encourages progress rather than paralysis. To that end, they can try role-playing. The following "Be Your Own Best Friend" exercise is well within the scope of their imaginations:

- List the negative things that you tell yourself about your life or actions. Try to come up with five or more.
- Put two chairs face-to-face.
- When you sit in one chair, you are simply you. When you sit in the other chair, you are your own best friend.
- Sit in "your" chair, and describe one of your negatives that you wrote down as if talking to your best friend.
- Switch chairs. As "your own best friend," reassure yourself as you would any friend. Explore any negative self-talk from a more compassionate perspective and search for balance and realistic implications.
- Do this until you have given yourself a good, positive talking-to about everything on your list.

Accepting a little help, especially from themselves, can help Mediators balance their needs and move their ideas forward.

Reconnecting

Human life and growth depend on insights and natural evolution. But the cosmos express life through action, and although it's impossible for humans to avoid all exertion of effort, it's possible to suppress the tendency. Some Mediators, at times, may avoid taking action by encapsulating themselves in their world of ideas and beliefs – endlessly

searching for meaning means never settling, and without the stability of definition, the foundation for building is shaky. However, those who self-evolve ask not only, "What I am about?" but also, "What is it that I do?"

Mediators interested in genuine self-development must break the cycle typical of their type, which resembles rumination punctuated by the hypnotic effects of inspirational moments. Self-evolution doesn't require abandoning the search for insight or ignoring moments filled with profound, self-actualizing experiences. It requires harnessing some of that energy to create something concrete. For these types, finding ways to do so can be a lifelong challenge, but one worth accepting and well within their abilities.

The following exercise can give Mediators a small taste of transforming a more emotional response into a concrete action:

- Find the most beautiful object available in the vicinity.
- Get a plain piece of paper and a pencil. A regular pencil is fine, but a colored pencil may make the exercise more interesting.
- Draw the object, trying to get as close to photographic accuracy as possible. This is a private exercise, so simply do your best.
- Should your mind drift toward more symbolic or abstract considerations, return to thoughts of lines, shadows, and shades. Be a camera more than an artist.
- Consider posting the picture or saving it as reminder to view things exactly as they are, rather than through a subjective filter.

Connecting to physical things can help Mediators balance their rich internal experience. Much like mindfulness mediation, the only goal is to notice the world as it is – rather than the way it should be. Mediators who manage such a balance create a paradigm in which they can enjoy the best of both realms.

Self-Responsibility

Self-responsibility sounds simple, but it can be difficult to practice. People who grasp a sense of self-responsibility decide matters for themselves, act independently, and follow interests without being excessively reliant on the opinions or permission of others.

Balanced Self-Responsibility

Morally Independent

Mediators test responsibility by running relevant issues through their ethical filters – filters which aren't necessarily limited to what society considers moral. Morals are the product of personal insight for these types, more so than the product of a cultural code, but the individual nature of their values doesn't make Mediators any less beholden to them.

As an example, Mediators are often sympathetic to those whom others may consider outcasts on moral or religious grounds. On some level, these types may feel a responsibility to at least ponder issues of fairness for those who are different, perhaps even staking out a radical position. As people with this type are so rare and often regarded as almost eccentric, it may be easy for them to identify with such groups. More importantly, however, their moral decisions come from within rather than from the masses.

In other words, Mediators' sense of responsibility is moral and independent in nature. Although they may benefit from the lessons of teachers and gurus and take them seriously, they aren't likely to let their final decisions rest on any teachings. This control from within matches the many other internal aspects of what it means to be Mediators.

Unbalanced Self-Responsibility

Becoming Helpless

The disconnect that some Mediators experience between their aspirations and their accomplishments can feel like constant failure in the face of constant effort. They may acquire a sense that, no matter what they do, they'll never gain traction, and eventually they start

asking themselves and people around them, "Why bother?" Because Mediators are so idealistic, their failures may be as innocuous as the everyday disappointments that come with perfectionism – with such a mentality, anything less than perfection is inadequate. Such frustrations can strip these types of their sense of control, leading them to conclude that they're helpless and powerless.

If Mediators believe that they have no control and that nothing is effective, they may conclude that there's no point in trying to do anything. Because of the moral overtones of their lives and their sensitivity, abdication of responsibility may result in a full-blown moral crisis. They may start to think of themselves as not just helpless people but as moral failures, and negative self-talk can once again gain a foothold.

Loss of Serenity

People often feel that they don't have control, not because it doesn't exist but because they convince themselves that it's absent. Others may lose it because they confuse the things they can control with the things they can't. For Mediators, who live so much in their imaginations, sorting out what is and isn't their responsibility can be more difficult because they're able to create so many varied scenarios in their minds. The dilemma can worsen when they have an abundance of principles and a sense of responsibility but no practical idea of how to use these assets.

Rebalancing Self-Responsibility

Helpless to Helpful

The best and most obvious way to beat an acquired sense of helplessness is success – which usually requires clear intentions and an action plan. Intention may come easily to Mediators, and they can learn to develop clarity and a plan of attack. Although they can certainly gain planning skills independently, they can also consider partnering with others who have already developed them or those who have a natural knack for getting things done. One of the best ways to learn is by doing, and such partnerships are likely to encourage participation, which leads to picking up helpful habits.

The following exercise requires some thought, a little planning, and a measure of action:

- Set a two-minute timer. Think of the nicest thing that can be done for a specific person.
- Set a 10-minute timer, and list the following things:
  - What actions are needed to fulfill the nice thing?
  - What resources will be needed, if any?
  - By what date and time will the nice thing be done?
- Follow the dictum, "Plan your work and work your plan."
- On completing the plan, celebrate by doing something nice for yourself.
- Repeat this exercise once a week for a month or more.

Discerning Control

Deciding what they can change and then making concrete, measurable plans to change it can help Mediators restore their sense of responsibility – but, first things first. Organizing the lush variety of ideas that constitute their consciousness into areas that they can and cannot influence themselves may help them determine, "What am I responsible for, and what am I not responsible for?"

However, sorting presents Mediators with choices. They may need to let go of things that they cannot control or allow themselves to go with the flow. Regarding the things that they can control, they may need to determine whether the situation needs controlling, whether the responsibility belongs to them, and how they should address their responsibility.

This exercise can help Mediators recognize and reflect upon their level of control:

- Wear a visually distinct or noticeable item, one that you wouldn't typically wear. This can be as simple as a rubber band or a piece of string, and as bold or obvious as you dare.

- Each time you or someone else takes notice of this accessory, ask yourself as a reflex, "What do I control in this situation? What is out of my control?"
- What reaction, if any, did this exercise elicit from other people? Were there any surprises?

It's hard to take responsibility without focus. Mediators need to connect to their values to discover the right motivations, focus on the things that they can control, and then commit to decisive and specific actions. When they manage their goals in this way, focus is likely to accompany them throughout their efforts.

Final Words

Creative and contemplative, Mediators often find inspiration within the depths of their own selves. But few Mediators experience the fulfillment that they crave by keeping their insight and creativity locked within their heads and their hearts. For people with this personality type, personal growth is largely about translating imagination and self-awareness into productive, positive action.

That's not to say that internal self-exploration isn't important – it certainly is, and Mediators' awareness of their own thoughts and emotions is among their greatest gifts. But for these types, the greatest growth often occurs when they attune their outward behaviors to their dreams, hopes, and ideals.

In moving through this guide, Mediators have learned about the different aspects of personal growth. They've cultivated inner awareness and appreciation, and they've also discovered the importance of setting their own direction and pursuing their goals in the world around them. Our hope is that these pages have not only shown Mediators how exhilarating and rewarding their personal growth journey can be, but also empowered them to make positive changes in their lives and the world around them.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this guide, dear Mediator, but fear not – we've created many more resources. Here are a few that might be the right next step for you:

- Looking for more tests and insights to help you direct your personal growth journey? Explore our Personal Growth Specialized Tests.
- Ready to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Mediator Guide to Careers*.
- Feeling adrift when it comes to your romantic relationships, friendships, or relationships with your children? Our *Mediator Guide to Relationships* may be just what you need.

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